

Jared Lomeli

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Dear Mr. Norris,

I have recently read your text "*A State of Extremes*" for my first-year writing class at San José State University. Your narrative focused on California's community colleges and it mirrored many parts of my own experience growing up and studying in this state. Your reflections have helped me see the bigger picture of how diverse and connected we all are within this community and state of California.

One of my favorite lines for me, was "*Ours is a divided state, but our paradox is that we are infinitely interconnected.*" This quote put something I have struggled so see into words. I've seen this firsthand between the neighborhoods where some people have to fight to be heard while others just ease by. I grew up on the blessed side where my parents had good jobs and were able to enjoy time with me. Although I have seen the other side. Just like the students you wrote about who had to balance their jobs with family and education, I now have to do that myself. I have slowly started becoming financially independent, with a lot of work to do, as well as balancing my family with religion and education. Through your reading, you reminded me that California's colleges aren't just schools, but communities where people can share memories with one another and make everlasting friends.

You write about traveling through mountain passes and freeways. Some of my family is all spread apart so I have seen a lot of freeways and driven them for hours. I also have relatives who worked through college to pay for their own education. Their stories have helped me recognize how blessed I am to be able to go to such a college such as San José State University.

Your narrative also made me think about what it means to be a student today. You wrote this during the week President Biden accounted student loan forgiveness, and even then, the economic pressure hadn't let up. I'm sure there are many students who still struggle to pay for food, transportation, books, education, and much more. I appreciate how you included that key point without including politics. Simply telling the truth of what happened can make a story so much more impactful.

Thank you for writing "*A state of Extremes*" for everyone to read. It made me see myself and the state of California more clearly. I also appreciate the time, honesty, and care that was put into this narrative.

Sincerely,

Jared Lomeli

San José State University